

Letter of Inquiry

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Abstract

In the past years, the spread of misinformation has been studied extensively by scholars from various scientific disciplines, therefore, relying on diverse conceptualizations. Definitions of misinformation seem to largely depend on the methodological nuances, resulting in inconclusive findings (Altay et al., 2023). In observational social media studies, researchers tend to rely on factchecked fake news at the story level (Vosoughi et al., 2018), or they follow blacklisted domains at the source level (González-Bailón et al., 2023; Guess et al., 2019; Grinberg et al., 2019; Robertson et al., 2023). While the usefulness of each approach depends on the specific research objectives, the latter has been shown to be scalable and reliable (Lin et al., 2023), yet suffering from low construct validity (as unreliable domains do not equal misinformation).

In the United States, one of the most prominent lists used for assessing misinformation is curated by the non-profit organization NewsGuard. NewsGuard employs an expert-based approach; assigning ratings based on nine distinct criteria and regularly updating these assessments. However, there are several challenges associated with this list: First, the domain ratings were first created as a tool for brand security rather than a research tool, which is why the list is proprietary and access as well as publication of the data is limited (and thereby blackboxed). Second, the coverage of the list has so far only been validated for research purposed for the U.S. context, where correlations were high given NewsGuard's focus (Lin et al., 2023). Still, it is crucial to assess the usefulness of this list for research beyond the English-speaking world.

Consequently, we propose to provide a comprehensive description of this list, outline its potential drawbacks, and ultimately offer recommendations for its application. More precisely, we believe that the following research questions are essential to be addressed:

1. How and when are ratings updated? How important is it to use up-to-date ratings? How do the results of our research projects change with different versions of NewsGuard? How many sources are added and dropped? Do I need to use multiple versions of the database, or is it enough to use one/the latest snapshots?
2. What is the coverage of countries and languages?

3. Alternative information? Political orientation? Rating criteria?

This is a test to check if the git works.